

Episode 8: Once Upon a Time... (6) Cel Paints Have a Sweet Fragrance That's Wonderful

The other day I went to see the movie "Bubble he GO!! Time Machine wa Drum-shiki." A story about time-travelling from 2007 to the bubble peak year 1990 to prevent the bubble's collapse and save Japan's near-bankrupt economy. **Hirosue Ryoko** love! **Abe Hiroshi** the best! It was quite an enjoyable movie and I was very satisfied.

Come to think of it, the stories I've been writing about from around 1985 are exactly bubble period stories. But personally, I don't really remember receiving any particular bubble benefits (bitter laugh).

Well then.

This week I'll return to the main story. About paints.

When I started finishing work at that Ikebukuro production company, since the finishing production I belonged to mainly took Toei work, the paints used there were naturally mostly STAC (Saito Tele-Anima Colours Co.Ltd) (スタック) paints. But occasionally, we'd take rush jobs from production companies other than Toei Doga, and most of those jobs used different paints from Toei's; the Taiyo Shikisai (太陽色彩)** paints.

Before entering the industry, I never imagined there were two paint manufacturers (actually there were many more companies making cel paints, but I learnt this much later). Moreover, the colours and numbering were different with subtle incompatibility. But thinking about it, the anime programmes I watched on TV back then - Toei works and works from other companies clearly had different screen brilliance and colour atmospheres, which I'd noticed even as an amateur. One major factor was the paint issue itself.

As I wrote about *Yamato* last time, STAC colours with overall vivid tones versus Taiyo Shikisai paints with matte tones. STAC colours that could appear transparent when painted thin versus Taiyo colours that were uniform in any colour and dried quickly. STAC colours with high transparency but prone to spoiling with rotten egg-like odours versus Taiyo colours that would quickly harden if you weren't careful. STAC colours that sometimes had fluffy white mould growing on the surface when you opened them versus Taiyo colours that could cause white clouding in finished painting if not well stirred.

As colour design or colour direction, which I preferred depends entirely on the case. When wanting vivid colours, STAC colours were good, and for subdued intermediate tones, definitely Taiyo Shikisai. Most of all, Taiyo colours had many colours and were easy to create gradations, but the numbering system was complex, often leading to specification and painting mistakes... (bitter laugh).

But for us doing finishing painting work on site, more than paint colour development, it was first about ease of painting and drying speed. Paint spread and brush movement favoured STAC colours, while drying speed favoured Taiyo Shikisai. Ah, colour trace work ease was definitely STAC colours. Especially STAC's "**Trace Black**" used for line corrections had very fine, smooth material quality and was the best paint for hand tracing.

(I think Taiyo Shikisai also had "Trace Black," but trace lines drawn with these paints had an enamel-like glossy reflection, and unfortunately they stuck easily to the protective "tissue paper" on cels and animation paper, making them hard to use back then...)

And the individual "quirks" of paints themselves were problematic. You had to know each paint's individual "quirks," or when you dried and collected the carefully painted cels and flipped them over, you'd end up going "Aggh!"

Following dim memories, STAC paint large bottles, called "kilo bottles," cost about 1,600 yen each back then, PB series (vivid pink colours) were slightly more expensive, and "Trace Black" was nearly 2,000 yen. I've forgotten the unit cost of raw cels. Incidentally, carbon for machine tracing was each subcontracting production company's burden. I think black carbon was about 20 yen per sheet. Brown and other coloured carbons were about 25 yen.

When I started work at the finishing production company, all materials for Toei works were supplied by Toei. Raw cels, paints - everything was provided by Toei. Finishing subcontractors only handled finishing work. For paints, when you ran out, you'd tell the finishing progress staff the colour number and they'd prepare it in advance so you could take it back with cuts (back then, shelves for each production company were set up in the finishing department for cut exchanges).

However, that "material supply" was suddenly discontinued one month, and while there was some upcharge to finishing unit costs as "material costs," everything else became each finishing production's burden. It was effectively a unit cost reduction. This was a big blow to finishing subcontractors back then. Well, other companies' works normally used this system. My production company and similar companies that mainly did Toei works increased the weight of non-Toei works from that point. This coincided with when animation production volume was starting to increase.

Even when Taiyo Shikisai paint jobs came in, they weren't constantly high volume, so naturally we couldn't afford to stock a complete set of Taiyo Shikisai paints. So what did we do? We used "conversion charts" to convert Taiyo colour specifications to STAC colours for painting.

"Conversion charts"! Every finishing production company used them back then. Sometimes each finishing production made and used their own, sometimes production companies brought them.

As I wrote earlier, Taiyo colours and STAC colours have basically no compatibility. Even grey paints have subtly different colours. So we very forcibly and roughly "converted" them for painting (laughs). It's unthinkable now, but back then it was OK even if colours were somewhat different.

For absolutely unavailable colours, we'd ask production progress staff to bring the necessary number of small bottles along with cuts. The Taiyo paints brought this way gradually increased as inventory. So when taking rush jobs, we'd start by rewriting colour specifications with our Taiyo paint inventory list in hand and calling to identify missing colours.

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